



Profile

Personal Information

Name	Ahona, John <i>Yoshi</i>
Share different name	No
Birthdate	06/06/2002
Pronouns	He/Him
Gender Identity	Male

Contact Details

Email, Phone	yoshiahona@gmail.com, +254.743088648, Mobile, +254.771475854, Mobile
Permanent Address	Kikuyu Kiambu, Kiambu, KEN

Demographics

Sex	Male
Military Status	None
Hispanic or Latino/a/x	No
Race	Black or African American (Africa)

Language

English	Speak, Read, Write
Swahili	First Language, Speak, Read, Write, Spoken at Home
Gikuyu	Speak
Other, Luhya	Speak, Spoken at Home

Geography and Nationality

Citizenship Status	Citizen of non-U.S. country
Birthplace	Nairobi, Kenya (0 Years US, Years Non-US)
Other Citizenships	Kenya
Current US Visa	None
Intended US Visa	F-1 Student

CA Fee Waiver

**Fee Waiver
Requested**

Yes, Signed: John Yoshi Ahona

My annual family income falls within the Income Eligibility Guidelines set by the USDA Food and Nutrition Service

I can provide a supporting statement from a school official, college access counselor, financial aid officer, or community leader

Family

Household

Parents	Widowed
Home	Parent 1

Parent 1

Mother

Name	Mrs. Mable N Wekesa
Email, Phone	mablewekesa08@gmail.com, +254.722634979, Mobile
Occupation	Other, Teacher, Vocational/Trade School, Employed, Nachu Technical and Vocational College, Kikuyu, KEN
Education	Some trade school or community college Other (1997), Kagumo Teachers Training College, KEN

Parent 2

Father

Name	Mr. Kenneth A Anusu
Deceased:	08/2008
Occupation	Teacher or administrator (elementary), Unemployed
Education	Graduated from trade school or community college Other (1995), University of Nairobi, KEN

Siblings

1. Finney Ahona, Age 20
2. Victor Ahona, Age 17
3. Timothy Anusu, Age 13

Education

Current or Most Recent Secondary School

Alliance High School, Kikuyu, KEN, Public, CEEB: 619330 (01/2017 - 04/2021)

Boarding School Yes: Living at School
Progression Did or will take gap year
Graduation Date 04/2021

Colleges & Universities

Grades

Rank 11 / 400, Unweighted

Current or Most Recent Year Courses

First Trimester	Second Trimester	Third Trimester
MATH - Mathematics - (REG)	MATH - Mathematics - (REG)	MATH - Mathematics - (REG)
ENG - English - (REG)	ENG - English - (REG)	ENG - English - (REG)
PHYS - Phycics - (REG)	PHYS - Phycics - (REG)	PHYS - Phycics - (REG)
CHEM - Chemistry - (REG)	CHEM - Chemistry - (REG)	CHEM - Chemistry - (REG)
BIOL - Biology - (REG)	BIOL - Biology - (REG)	BIOL - Biology - (REG)
SCI - Electricity - (REG)	SCI - Electricity - (REG)	SCI - Electricity - (REG)
ENVSCI - Geography - (REG)	ENVSCI - Geography - (REG)	ENVSCI - Geography - (REG)
LANG - Kiswahili - (REG)	LANG - Kiswahili - (REG)	LANG - Kiswahili - (REG)

Honors

Kenya National Team Member, in the 61st and 62nd International Mathematics Olympiad, Russia/virtual.	International	11, 12
Honorable Mention, 28th Pan-African Mathematics Olympiad, Tunisia (Virtual).	International	12

Position 1, Brookside Mathematics Contest.	National	9, 10, 11, 12
Position 1, Interswitch STEM Contest (Kenya) and Top 6 in Interswitch Pan-African Contest (Nigeria).	National	11
Position 2, Kiambu Regional Chess Tournament.	State/Regional	11, 12

Community-Based Organizations

CBO 1	KenSAP (Kenya Scholar Access Program)
Counselor	Mr. Alan Davidson
Email, Phone	alan@kensap.org, +1.917-242-0599

Future Plans

Other, Mathematician, Doctorate

Testing

Leaving Exams

Mathematics	A	04/2021, Actual, KCSE
English	A-	04/2021, Actual, KCSE
Kiswahili	A	04/2021, Actual, KCSE
Phycics	A	04/2021, Actual, KCSE
Chemistry	A	04/2021, Actual, KCSE
Biology	A	04/2021, Actual, KCSE
Geography	A	04/2021, Actual, KCSE
Electricity	A	04/2021, Actual, KCSE

Activities

Academic

PG	Scholar/Lead Math Instructor, KenSAP (Kenya Scholar Access Program)
Year	
84 hr/wk, 15 wk/yr	Worked on college applications, completed liberal arts seminars in various subjects, and prepare for SATs.

Student Govt./Politics

12	Academic Captain, Alliance High School
School	Counseled and guided peers in Academics, chaired academic committee meetings, organized peer tutoring, and served in the library.
20 hr/wk, 36 wk/yr	

Other Club/Activity

12	Chairman, Mathematics Club
School	Prepared and coordinated the school team for contests, trained the school's Math Olympiad team, and organized inter-house Math contests.
20 hr/wk, 32 wk/yr	

Other Club/Activity

12	Vice Captain, Chess Club
School	Organized interhouse tournaments, trained the school chess team for national competitions, and taught chess strategy and theory to members.
20 hr/wk, 30 wk/yr	

Work (Paid)

PG	Editor, Topnotch Publishers
Year	Proofread, edited and improved content in Topnotch Chemistry books and solved math-related problems in the textbooks, to be used by KCSE candidates.
30 hr/wk, 8 wk/yr	

Computer/Technology

PG	Student, Introduction to Computer Science and Programming at MITx
Year	
40 hr/wk, 5 wk/yr	Covered the theory of computation, fundamentals of computer science, basic programming, software development, and data structures.

Work (Paid)

PG	Team Trainer, Kenya Mathematics Olympiad
Year	Trained 40 students for the Kenya Mathematical Olympiad. 6 of them will be proceeding to the International Mathematical Olympiad.
10 hr/wk, 24 wk/yr	
Continue	

Science/Math

12	Alliance High School Team Member, Kenya Science and Engineering Fair
School	
5 hr/wk, 4 wk/yr	Researched the electrostatic properties of human hair and created a hair strand capacitor.
Continue	

Community Service (Volunteer)

PG	Math and Science Tutor, Nachu Primary school
Year	Worked individually with students to improve their performance, answered questions about lessons, and supervised group activities.
40 hr/wk, 8 wk/yr	

Community Service (Volunteer)

PG	Academic Tutor, RefugeeTeach, Kakuma Refugee Camp
Year	Taught Math and Physics to refugee students remotely, worked individually with students to improve their performance, and organized group activities.
10 hr/wk, 16 wk/yr	

Writing

Personal Essay

Some students have a background, identity, interest, or talent that is so meaningful they believe their application would be incomplete without it. If this sounds like you, then please share your story.

Looking down at the River Nzoia from the heights of the Chetambe Hills, I used to feel myself at the edge of the world. Of course, it was merely the edge of my village, Webuye, in far western Kenya, but that *was* my world. When I last stood there, I had just been admitted to the college access program KenSAP, and I knew my world was about to expand, and I reflected on how far I had already come.

The rainy season had begun, and the scent of guava trees filled the air, along with the chattering of monkeys jumping from tree to tree. Mushrooms sprouting from the spongy ground reminded me of lessons learned in childhood about which ones made good eating and which ones caused a day of stomach pains. In the valley, an old cargo train crawled toward the Uganda border spewing exhaust as several of my villagers ran beside it and leapt on, hoping for opportunities in distant places. A deserted paper factory that might once have employed them stood at the foot of the Hills' forested western slopes. It now shelters criminals and drug abusers, while those who want to work sell crops by the roadside or quarry stones from the hills. As I thought about Webuye's bleak prospects, I heard whispers in the bush behind me. "Ni uria watira masomo vilayi." (He's the one who won everything in school). I turned and saw a few small children staring at me. I smiled and offered some clichés about the importance of doing well in school.

I was about their age when my father died. He had been a primary school teacher working during off hours towards a mid-career degree, and he firmly believed education was the only road out of poverty. My mother, also a teacher, repeated the same mantra, but at six years old I could see little hope. Crippled with debt from my father's medical bills, we had to move to a room in the abandoned paper factory, surrounded by squalor and misery. My brothers and I had to switch schools to a local public primary school, where no fees were charged, and little education was provided. We walked three kilometers each morning to a dilapidated building where there were not enough books, desks, or teachers. After school, we fetched water and firewood, dug in the garden with our *jembes*, and found casual work quarrying stones. Yet my mother kept repeating that education was our only chance, and I began to believe her.

I developed a special interest in Mathematics that sticks with me today. I loved learning how numbers explained the world around me, and I started to explore that world in a scientific manner. The hills offered opportunities to calculate the rate of flowing water, the garden became a place for imagining laws behind botanical forms, and our precarious finances called for my skills to plan family budgets.

At the end of my last year in primary school, when national exam results were announced, there was a frenzied celebration in the whole village. I had been selected to join Alliance High School, Kenya's most admired educational institution. The villagers knew that one of their own would journey to far off Nairobi and might come back with opportunities for all. They collected enough to pay my first year's fees, and a few weeks later, my mother and I traveled almost 24 hours across seventeen counties to arrive at Alliance.

I was naturally thrilled to join Kenya's best high school, and while I soon found myself facing a whole new set of challenges, as I said goodbye to my mother at Alliance's imposing gates – and listened as she reminded me again that education was our hope for the future – I felt I had crossed the edge of a much wider world.

Community Disruption

When the pandemic hit Kenya around March 2020, I was just starting my final year of high school and had planned to take part in many exciting global opportunities. I had just qualified for the International Mathematics Olympiad to be held in Russia. The thought of going to Russia had enthralled me and I couldn't wait to go for the

gold. However, my dreams were shattered when the pandemic closed Kenyan schools and brought international travel to a halt.

Although the chances of traveling abroad vanished, I kept taking part in other competitions and was very excited when I qualified for the 62nd International Mathematics Olympiad, which was, coincidentally, to be hosted by Russia. It was also canceled, along with another trip to Tunisia for The Pan African Olympiad.

Moreover, the suspension of in-person learning affected me, as it did many low-income students in the country. Staying at home in one of the most remote parts of the world with very limited access to the internet provided the least conducive environment for learning. Being at home also meant having to help out with the household chores, and I worked odd jobs to help my family make ends meet.

The COVID-19 pandemic has had a devastating impact on every corner of the world. While I feel bad about all the life-changing travel opportunities I missed out on and the learning disruption at a crucial moment of my life, I am just grateful to be alive and healthy.

Additional Information

In my Personal Essay, I said Alliance High School presented both new challenges and new opportunities. I want to expand on that here.

I can't really compare Alliance to my dilapidated primary school. The Alliance gatehouse alone seemed larger than my entire primary school compound, and the Alliance campus is about as large as my whole village. The school's resources seemed limitless. There were books and desks for all students, the teachers were the country's best, and the food filled our stomachs thrice daily. There were libraries, laboratories, clubs, academic counselors, career counselors, and alumni days. Alliance was an educational paradise, but adjusting to it was not easy.

As Kenya's most prestigious high school, Alliance attracted many students from wealthy families who spoke English at home. My Luhya accent and rural upbringing marked me as a bumpkin to the "city kids." I was teased and bullied and at first, and the socio-economic distinctions dented my self-esteem, but by the end of my first year I emerged as the top student in Form 1 and that erased most of the barriers. Moreover, as a low-income student with high scores, I was awarded a scholarship from Centum Investment Company which paid my fees, gave me pocket money, and even enabled me to send money home to my mother.

My success in quantitative subjects led to my representing Alliance in math contests across the country. As stories of my achievements in these contests spread in school, I made more friends and took on leadership positions, such as Chairman of the Mathematics Club and, in Form 3, schoolwide Academics Captain. Also in Form 3, I came first in a national STEM contest and was invited to a Pan-African competition in Nigeria sponsored by the technology company Interswitch.

I remember wandering through Nairobi's bustling Jomo Kenyatta International Airport trying to soak up the novel experiences, from security checks to searching for my seat among sophisticated international travelers. I imagine every child in Kenya has gazed upward at noisy winged machines and dreamed of one day flying – and there I was. How far I had come from the days when I was thrilled if a motorcyclist gave me a lift to primary school.

Landing in Lagos I found myself in a new culture. I immediately noticed peoples' lyrical accents and the body language that animated casual conversations. Of course, there were new foods and music, and I noticed how the presence of the ocean influenced life in Lagos. I also learnt how Nigeria's oil economy affected the country and wondered if Kenyans, even with our many problems, were lucky we didn't have oil attracting nefarious international partners.

During the competition I made friends with students from Ghana and Nigeria, and though I didn't win, just travelling

across the continent was reward enough. I began to feel I was not only Kenyan but African, with an enlarged community and bigger dreams. Once again, the edge of my world moved outward.

The next year mathematics almost brought me another chance to widen my world, this time through the International Mathematics Olympiad to be held in Russia. Unfortunately, COVID cancelled our journey, but the remote competition was still exciting. In May, the national exam results were announced, prompting another celebration in my village. I had scored a straight A and would have a chance to apply to universities abroad. Village elders sat me down and told me I should go far with my education and help pull Webuye out of poverty. I recalled my parents' words, but this time the whole community was involved.

Naturally I want to help my village, but I also want to experience the world's cultures and gain perspective on global concerns as well as those of Webuye and Kenya. I want to influence the next generation of learners, to keep reaching beyond my limits, and keep moving the edge of my world outward.

Education Progression

Education progression details

Did or will take gap year

Required Explanation

Education progression

In Kenya, newly graduated high school students are required to stay at home for months before joining universities. During this time I engaged in several activities to stay productive.

After sitting the KCSE exam in April, I went back home. I became a Math and Science tutor at the neighboring Nachu Primary School. Concurrently, I worked with Topnotch Publishers where I edited Math and Chemistry books and also came up with practice questions and answers, before the books were published and made available for use by students.

I used my free time to gain computer skills. I took a class on Data Science from EdX through Harvard University, earning a certificate with an A+, as well as Introduction to Computer Science and Programming Using Python offered by MIT. I did not earn a certificate for the latter since I could not afford the exam fee. I also improved my Mathematics skills by teaching myself Higher Calculus and an Introduction to Pure Mathematics. I read, "Advanced Calculus" by George Simmons.

Additionally, I have been improving on my chess skills. I play chess online at Lichess, and take part in online tournaments organized by Swiss Prox chess team. I have won two tournaments so far. I recently got a FIDE ID and hoping to take part in International Chess Federation tournaments.

In July, I was accepted into KenSAP, a college access program for high-achieving, low-income Kenyan students. Since July, I have been living with KenSAP students and preparing my college applications.

Princeton University Questions

General

Preferred start term	Fall 2022
Admission plan	Restrictive Early Action
Please indicate which name you would like us to use for print and email communication from Princeton's Office of Admission.	First name
Princeton-specific Fee Waiver	Common App
Financial aid	Yes
Portfolio Slideroom	No
Have you ever been found responsible for a disciplinary violation at any educational institution you have attended from the 9th grade (or the international equivalent) forward, whether related to academic misconduct or behavioral misconduct, that resulted in a disciplinary action? These actions could include, but are not limited to: probation, suspension, removal, dismissal, or expulsion from the institution.	No

**Princeton Alumni
Interview Consent**

I would like to share my contact information and high school name with Princeton alumni interviewers, for the purpose of contacting me to arrange an alumni interview.

Academics

**Which degree
would you most
likely pursue at
Princeton? Your
choice is not
binding in any way:**

A.B.

As a research institution that also prides itself on its liberal arts curriculum, Princeton allows students to explore areas across the humanities and the arts, the natural sciences, and the social sciences. What academic areas most pique your curiosity, and how do the programs offered at Princeton suit your particular interests? (Please respond in about 250 words)

Since childhood I have understood the world through numbers. For example, I calculated how many jerry cans of water we needed for an entire week, and I helped my mother with financial planning to stretch her meagre earnings. It follows that my academic first love is Mathematics. At Princeton, I hope to join classes such as “Math Alive,” clubs such as the Princeton University Math Club, and the Seminar Series in the Mathematics Department. That all these opportunities exist at Princeton shows that there is a robust community of math-lovers who share my conviction that math is fun. I can see myself in Fine Hall, researching magic, tricks, and games with Professor Manjul Bhargava, and preparing to represent Princeton at the Putnam Competition. I am intrigued by the Math in Moscow program, and I may explore the Certificate Program in Applied and Computational Mathematics to learn how to apply math to real-world problems from Cellular Biology to Economics.

In addition to all this, I also hope Princeton’s liberal arts curriculum will broaden my up-to-now limited horizons and sharpen the tools I need to become involved in addressing complex world issues. I will balance my math studies with classes in African Studies, Philosophy, and Psychology, as well as Entrepreneurship and Public Policy to learn about working with governments and businesses to aid Kenya’s development. Albert Einstein once said, “the greatest scientists are also artists,” and I believe Princeton will give me an education in both arts and sciences.

**In which program
of study do you
think you would
like to major at
Princeton? Your
choice is not
binding in any way:**

Mathematics

**In which second
program of study
do you think you
would like to major
at Princeton? Your
choice is not
binding in any way:**

Economics

**In addition to the
major you noted
above, please
indicate which
certificate program
might interest you:**

Applied and Computational Mathematics

In addition to the major you noted above, please indicate which second choice certificate program might interest you:

African Studies

Princeton will allow students to apply for admission to the Class of 2026 with or without SAT or ACT scores. Students who do not submit standardized test scores will not be at a disadvantage in the admission process. Please select one option below:

I would like my application to be considered without ACT or SAT scores

Previous Applicants

Previously applied No

Family

Sibling applied No

Family: No

Relative employed at member No

Number of Parents, Step-Parents or Guardians 1

Parent, Step-parent or Guardian 1 Relationship Mother

Parent, Step-parent or Guardian 1 First Name Mable

Parent, Step-parent or Guardian 1 Last Name Wekesa

Parent, Step-parent or Guardian 1 Occupation Other

Parent, Step-parent or Guardian 1 Position/Title Teacher, Vocational School

Parent, Step-parent or Guardian 1 Employment Status Employed

Parent, Step-parent or Guardian 1 Birth Country Kenya

Parent different address No

Number of Siblings 3

Additional Sibling Information

Finney Ahona, 2nd Year, No Degree, Kenyatta University

Victor Ahona, Form 4, Nairobi School (Secondary School)

Timothy Anusu, Class 7, Kanyiha Primary School

Affirmations

By submitting this application, I affirm my understanding of and agreement to the statements found here:
<http://www.commonapp.org/affirmations>.